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B 1 www.kansascity.com/news THE KANSAS CITY STAR. Sunday, January 6, 2002



Twelve Tribes member Ben Shimon pours beeswax into molds for honey pot lids. The community supports itself largely through the sale of handcrafted furniture and beeswax products.

Disciples maintain a life of simplicity

Despite controversy, group lives quietly

By MATT STEARNS
The Kansas City Star

WARSAW, Mo. — Here in central Missouri, members of the Twelve Tribes religious group welcome visitors with gentle smiles and quiet conversation.

They break from dipping beeswax candles and baking bread to explain why they live the way they do: separately, simply, at odds with the wider culture — and, in some places, authorities.

Although their Missouri neighbors have had few complaints, in other states, at other times, Twelve Tribes members have been characterized as cultists, child abusers and anti-Semites and have spent years confronting public ridicule and prosecutorial zeal.

They hope their explanation falls on sympathetic ears. If it does not, they make no apologies.

"The devil always tells lies about the truth," said Michael Skinner, an elder of Twelve Tribes, which derives its name from the Old Testament.

Twelve Tribes has about 2,500 members. The group, whose faith is based on its interpretation of the Bible, has headquarters in Vermont and several outposts around the world. Most of its members live in the northeast United States. Members often move among Tribes communities.

See TRIBES, B-12

KC drunken driving arrests drop

By CHRISTINE VENDEL
The Kansas City Star

Drunken driving arrests declined in Kansas City for last year's first 11 months despite a new Missouri law that made it easier to charge intoxicated motorists.

Police officials attributed the drop to a shortage of officers who specialize in arresting drunken drivers and to a shortage of patrol officers. This year they are trying to get

Police Department cites officer shortage

more officers on the DUI squad and will deploy officers to get more arrests.

Through November, Kansas City police arrested 1,910 drivers on drunken driving charges, a drop of 14 percent from the same time in 2000. Year-end statistics were unavailable.

The most recent numbers con-

tinued a trend since 1992 that showed drunken driving arrests falling. Authorities attributed some of the decline to increased awareness about alcohol's danger.

Last year's drop, however, surprised officials.

They expected a 10 percent to 20 percent increase in arrests with the new law. The measure, which went

into effect in August, lowered the legal blood alcohol limit to .08 percent from .10 percent.

For the entire year, the DUI unit was below strength, which caught the attention of the Heartland chapter of Mothers Against Drunk Driving.

Chapter President Lela McDuffy said the police unit needed more officers.

See ARRESTS, B-2

Metro WATCH

SIGN
OF THE TIMES

Opal Hoke never thought patriotism could cause so much trouble.

A week after the terrorist attacks, she and her husband, Benny, placed a large, yellow-and-green lighted sign on their front lawn. The sign, measuring about 4 feet by 5 feet, sits on Hoke's property a few feet back from a heavily traveled stretch of road. It reads: "United We Stand, Pray for America."

Now the city of Independence has sent the Hokes a letter telling them the sign violates city regulations. They must remove it or face a \$500 fine and possible jail time.

Larry Minaarik, planning director in the city's community development department, said a complaint about the sign started several contacts with the Hokes.

Lighted signs are not allowed at Independence residences. Minaarik said he has agreed to drop the matter if the Hokes unplug the lights and take the sign down within 60 days of Jan. 1.

Opal Hoke said she would like to keep the sign until all U.S. troops are home and the war is over.

Her husband says he believes he has figured out a way to stand by his principles, even if it means a little cat and mouse with the city.

"I already spoke to a neighbor of mine. We figure I can sell him the sign at the end of 60 days, and he can put it in his yard for 60 days," he said. That way we are all happy."

CODE OF CONDUCT

This took an official act? Missouri Senate leaders have adopted a code of conduct for staffers, which they touted as a first in Missouri history.

The conduct code includes restrictions on staffers using their job for personal gain, taking public property or slacking off on their duties, among other things.

As a general principle, the code says Senate staffers "shall approach their duties with a positive attitude."

Which gives rise to the obvious question: What were they doing before?



RUFFLED
FEATHERS

Overland Park's convention center is supposed to be a boon for the city's economy when it opens in December.

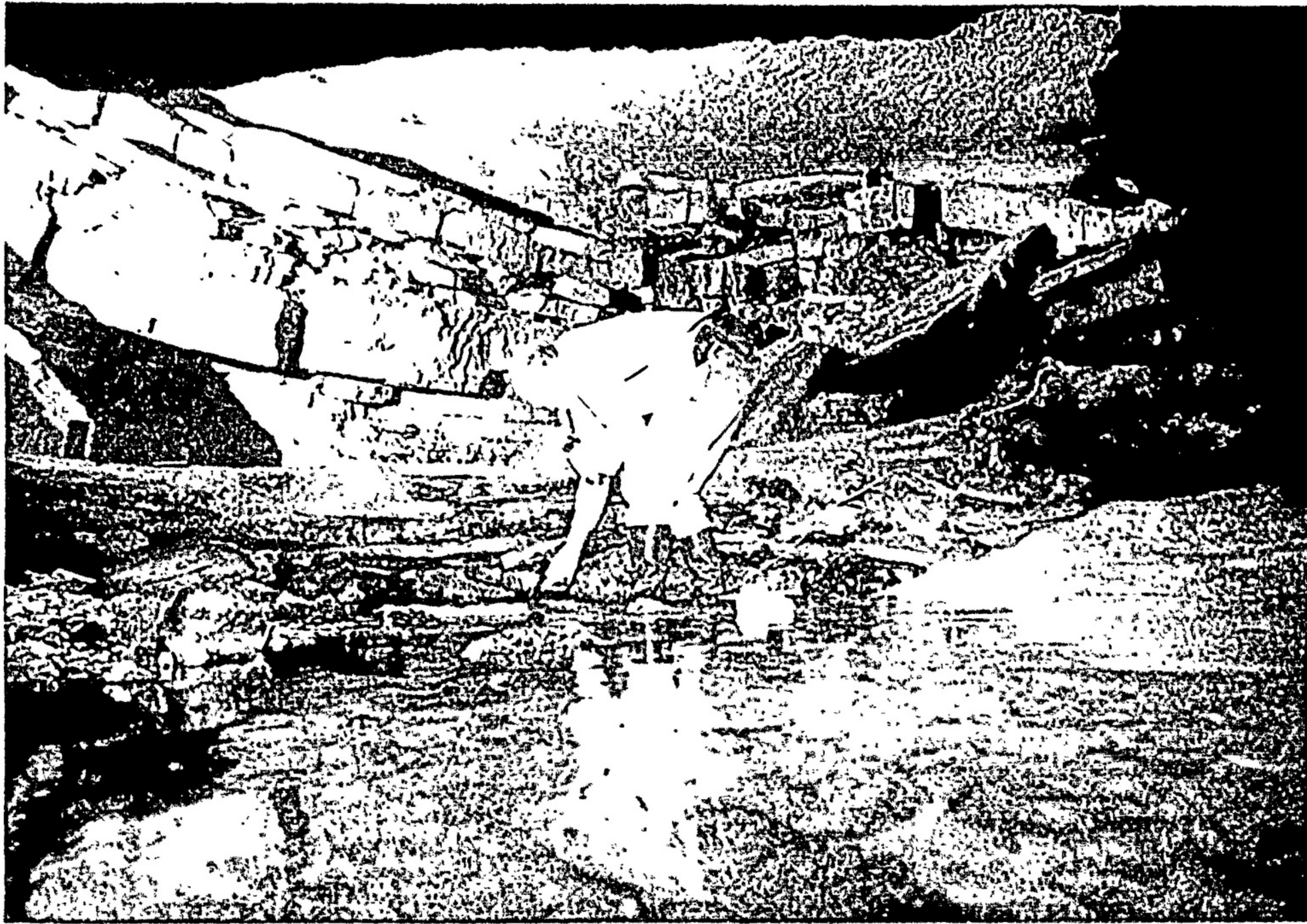
So it's easy to understand why some Overland Park officials were chagrined when their city was left off a list of local attractions on a flier promoting a Sheraton Hotel and the adjacent center.

Put together by the hotel's marketing director, the flier listed Missouri locales such as Worlds of Fun, Union Station and the Country Club Plaza.

The flier also noted Leawood's Town Center Plaza. Not mentioned was Overland Park's own Oak Park Mall.

Overland Park officials brought the issue to the attention of Sheraton operators, who have since swapped Town Center Plaza for Oak Park Mall on subsequent fliers.

State's 'No. 1 cave guy'



KATHY MYLEN/The Kansas City Star

Deep inside Tumbling Creek Cave, Tom Aley changes a dye-trapping charcoal filter that will help him determine the source and quality of

the water that streams through his cave. Aley is a pioneer in the study of underground ecosystems.

Missourian pioneers study of underground world

By BILL GRAHAM
The Kansas City Star

PROTEM, Mo. — The Tumbling Creek cavesnail, no bigger than a grain of sand, owes its earthly survival to Tom and Cathy Aley.

Their lifetime study of caves and underground water systems led to the tiny creature's discovery and later the realization that the species was vanishing. On Dec. 27 the snail was given immediate

protection on the federal endangered species list. Earlier in December, it was placed on the Missouri endangered species list.

Yet cavesnails are only a tiny part of the Aleys' pioneering work that experts say has worldwide impact on how landowners, drinking water suppliers and scientists view land and underground water systems.

Somehow, though, Tom Aley views himself as the debtor.

"I get a great deal of enjoyment

out of this, and it's been very good to me," Aley, 63, said recently as he turned over rocks to look for cavesnails in a stream tumbling melodically through the dark passages of the cave he owns. "I'm trying to return that favor."

His way of paying back is investing 35 years and \$1.4 million in the Ozark Underground Laboratory, east of Branson in Taney County. At the heart is the Aleys' Tumbling Creek Cave and 2,500

acres of land that drains water into it. Paying the bills are some of the most sophisticated laboratories in the world for tracing underground water flow with fluorescent dyes.

The tracing determines the direction, location and speed of water flow, useful in preventing pollution in underwater drinking supplies or in fragile cave and spring ecosystems.

See CAVES, B-2

To achieve true justice, hold accountable those truly at fault

In the paper the other day there was a story about a weatherman in Rio de Janeiro who could face criminal charges and jail time for getting a forecast wrong.

The meteorologist, a veteran of 35 years in the business, predicted that a cold front would dump heavy rains on a city already traumatized by recent floods. But the front dissipated, the downpour didn't come, and Rio's mayor wants the poor devil prosecuted.

That may sound a bit harsh, since divining the weather is as much art as science. But the idea of accountability for one's errors does have a certain appeal.

Years ago, I gave a sum of money to a stockbroker. In not much more than a year, he made it disappear — investing in vacation camper homes a week after the OPEC oil

embargo, then sinking what was left in production of a movie whose awfulness still is legend more than 20 years later.

To my lasting regret, I did nothing — just licked my wounds and went on. But surely the rascal deserved at least what the Rio weatherman seems likely to get.

I thought of that when I read the tragic stories of those employees whose savings, locked in shares of Enron stock, went up in smoke, although the top officers seem to have gotten out with millions before the company's collapse.

And I thought of it again when I saw recently that the largest U.S. meat processor, Tyson Foods Inc., had been charged in federal court with conspiring to transport undocumented immigrants into the country and helping them get bogus

COMMENTARY



C.W. GUSEWELLE

work papers.

Authorities say the practice is common in the meat-packing industry. The immigrant laborers are willing to toil for one-third of the wage that the plants used to pay union workers. Often they receive no benefits, and they are powerless to complain about dangerous working conditions.

It's reported that some of the companies actively solicit for undocumented workers, advertising on the radio and employing smugglers to bring new hires across the border. Estimates have put the numbers in the hundreds of thousands.

Raids on the plants have resulted in many immigrants being sent back to their home countries, but the effort to stem the flow — mostly from Mexico and Guatemala — is opposed by the meat companies that profit from cheap labor, and by civil rights advocates who say Latin Americans are unfairly made targets.

Even the Department of Agriculture, though it does not sanction breaking the law, admits that the industry, like other segments of U.S. agriculture, is critically dependent on foreign labor.

My misadventure with the broker is far in the past. And the Rio weatherman will have to sort things out for himself. But on the knotty issue of undocumented packing-house workers, a possible remedy comes immediately to mind.

That is, give the ones already in the country green cards and other necessary papers that would enable them to remain here and work legally.

And deport permanently to Mexico and Guatemala the CEOs and other top executives of the companies that brought them in.

Granted, it might be a tad difficult to get that law written on the books. But I guarantee it would cause the offenders to rethink their hiring practices overnight.

Sometimes the best solution to a problem is the simplest one.

